



NiCare IN THE LAST ONE YEAR

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His Excellency
Farmer Mohammed Umaru Bago

Preamble

The maiden edition of the NiCare Newsletter celebrates a year of remarkable achievements. This publication serves as a comprehensive showcase of NiCare's activities, milestones, and contributions to improving healthcare delivery across Niger State.

In this edition, we highlight the Agency's commitment to providing affordable and accessible health insurance to the residents of the State.

The newsletter also reflects on our pragmatic effort as an Agency, emphasizing our strategic approach to strengthening health systems, fostering partnerships, and building the capacity of healthcare workers to deliver quality services.

Beyond showcasing our activities, NiCare's mission is to make healthcare a reality for all and reiterate its alignment with His Excellency, Farmer Mohammed Umaru Bago's improved livelihoods goal of the NEW NIGER agenda. It also serves as a platform to share impactful stories, highlight lessons learned, and inspire stakeholders to continue their support for the agency's goals.

As NiCare moves forward, this marks the beginning of a new era of transparency, engagement, and innovation in healthcare service delivery.



Sulayman Abu-bakr^{MPH}

Executive Secretary/ CEO
Niger State Contributory Health Agency
(NiCare)

FOR MORE INFORMATION

Visit www.nicare.nigerstate.gov.ng



Niger State Contributory Health Agency - NiCare



NiCareHealth

About Us

The Niger State Contributory Health Agency (NiCare) was established following the passage of the law that created the Niger State Contributory Health Scheme in 2018.

NiCare is an Agency established with the core mandate of implementing the Contributory Health Scheme which operates on the principles of harmony, risk sharing and pooling of resources for the provision of affordable, accessible and qualitative health care services for the residents of Niger State on sustainable basis.

Overall
Mission

To facilitate easy healthcare financing through pooling and judicious utilization of financial resources to provide financial risk protection and cost burden sharing for people against high cost of healthcare through prepayment programmes.

The Mandate of NiCare
Ensure that every resident of Niger state has access to good healthcare services.
Protect families from financial hardship of huge medical bills.
Limit rise in the cost of healthcare services by ensuring equitable distribution of healthcare cost among different groups.

New Niger Agenda Alignment

- Access to Quality Health
- Access to Quality & Inclusive Education
- Environmental Sanitation
- Access to Portable Water
- Gender Equity
- Affordable Housing
- Elderly Care
- Special Needs People



Assumption of Duty

Sulayman Abu-Bakr assumed office on the 4th of January, 2024 as the The Executive Secretary/ CEO of the Niger State Contributory Health Agency- NiCare.



Sulayman Abu-bakr was warmly received by the Honorable Commissioner of Secondary and Tertiary Health Dr. Bello Tukur, Ministry directors, and Staff members as the newly appointed Executive Secretary of the Niger State Contributory Health Agency (Nicare) on the 4th of January, 2024. The Honorable Commissioner emphasized the collective duty to build a 'New Niger'. He called for unity, stressing the importance of everyone's contribution to ensuring the ministry meets its obligations to the people of Niger State. He also highlighted the Governor's concern about residents seeking medical care outside the state due to perceived inadequacies, emphasizing the imperative to enhance NiCare's services to curtail medical tourism and provide affordable, quality healthcare locally. Pharm. Attahiru Shehu Malagi, a Director Programmes and Business Development, assured the new Executive Secretary of their unwavering support. Expressing gratitude, Executive Secretary Abu-bakr thanked them and the Governor for the trust vested in him and commended the ministry staff for their warm reception. He pledged to diligently pursue

the objectives of the 'New Niger' vision set forth by the Governor.

The Executive Secretary, Abu-bakr brings over a decade of experience that spanned both public and private sector: Zuma Health Trust HMO and the National Primary Health Care Development Agency (NPHCDA). Throughout his career, he has played a pivotal role in enhancing primary healthcare delivery through Health System strengthening approach by, leveraging technology to drive advancements in Population Health.



Management Retreat



The Executive Secretary's Strategic Blueprint unveiled

The Niger State Contributory Health Agency held a three-day retreat, themed "Affordable Healthcare Services Towards Improving Livelihood," was held at Guddel Hotel from Tuesday 16th April to Thursday 18th February, 2024. The retreat, which brought together management staff and program leads, aimed to align the team with NiCare's strategic objectives and the broader New Niger Agenda.



The event focused on streamlining institutional and programmatic priorities, finalizing a costed work plan for 2024 in alignment with the Executive Secretary's (ES) strategic blueprint, and exploring opportunities to restructure the Agency's organizational framework and workforce for optimal implementation of its overarching goals.

A key highlight of the retreat was the unveiling of the Executive Secretary's strategic vision for the Agency, encapsulated in a four-point plan designed to guide NiCare's activities over the next four years.

The retreat also featured breakout sessions, during which each department developed templates to align their activities and achievements with the ES's strategic blueprint. These sessions culminated in presentations by department heads, showcasing their contributions toward achieving the Agency's goals.

The retreat concluded with a dissemination session to present the strategic plan aimed at transforming the future of the Agency. This plan emphasized expanding health insurance coverage, leveraging digitization, and fostering collaboration with stakeholders, including government bodies, the private sector, and development partners in Niger State. Stakeholders lauded the Executive Secretary's transformative vision and pledged their full support for its implementation.



NiCare Strategic Blueprint



Purpose

Drive equitable access to basic minimum service package of healthcare that is qualitative and acceptable to consumers



Vision

A reliable scheme that ensures access to affordable quality healthcare to all the people of Niger State

NiCare Four Independent Principles



CLIENT CENTERED

Healthcare services must resonate with the needs of the clients.



EQUITABLE ACCESS TO BASIC HEALTHCARE SERVICES

All Nigerlites irrespective of socioeconomic and demographic characteristics, and place of residence must have access to qualitative healthcare services that must satisfy their needs.



ACCOUNTABILITY

Taking ownership of actions and results while ensuring each party fulfills his/her obligations.



FINANCIAL RISK PROTECTION

Ensuring that individuals and households are protected from the financial burden of accessing healthcare services.

NiCare Strategic Plan



Expanding Partnerships

Partnership between NiCare and Niger Foods



The Governor facilitated the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between NiCare and Niger Foods to extend health insurance coverage to 350,000 farmers. In a landmark initiative to rejuvenate the agricultural sector in Niger State, His Excellency, the Farmer Governor Mohammed Umaru Bago, facilitated a strategic partnership between the Agency and the Niger Food Security Systems and Logistics Company Limited through the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU). This collaboration aims to enroll 350,000 farmers into the State Health Insurance Scheme, representing a pivotal step in the state's pursuit of agricultural transformation and economic advancement. The initiative is designed not only to bolster food production and security but also to enhance the economic well-being of the state's residents. By fostering sustainable growth in agriculture and improving access to essential healthcare services, this effort positions Niger State as a leading agrarian society, resilient amidst prevailing economic challenges.



Partnership between NiCare and State-owned Tertiary Institutions

On the 14th August 2024, NiCare signed a Memorandum of Agreement to collaborate with state-owned Tertiary Institutions. This is to enhance and provide access to quality healthcare for students in Niger State.

The ES, Sulayman Abu-bakr, MPH, in his speech, emphasized that the Tertiary Institutions Social Health Insurance Programme (TSHIP) aligns with His Excellency Farmer Umaru Mohammed Bago New Niger Agenda to transform healthcare and improve the livelihood and well-being of all Niger State residents, including students.

His Excellency, the Farmer Governor Mohammed Umaru Bago represented by The Head of Service Engr Abubakar Salisu, The Commissioner of Secondary and Tertiary Health, The Commissioner for Education and Heads of Tertiary institutions were all present to witness the historic event.



GAVI/ UNICEF Official flag off



GAVI (The Vaccine Alliance) / UNICEF Official flag off

Niger State Contributory Health Agency officially flagged off enrollment of GAVI UNICEF beneficiaries to reduce zero dose and burden in Niger state. During the flag off of enrollment at Old Airport Clinic Minna, the Commissioner Ministry of Secondary and Tertiary Health, Dr Bello Tukur, said the ministry is collaborating with GAVI-UNICEF to reduce childhood illness/vaccine preventable diseases. The Commissioner commended the supporting partners for their support across the six Local Government Areas in the state.



Also speaking, the Executive Secretary NiCare, Sulayman Abu-bakr, who spoke on the benefits of the enrollment, called on parents to take advantage of NiCare services to reduce maternal and infant mortality and improve quality of life. Speaking on behalf of UNICEF Kaduna Field Office, led by Mrs Grace Odeyemi said the initiative reflects a shared commitment to achieving universal immunization coverage and strengthening the health system to protect every Child, especially the most vulnerable, from vaccine preventable diseases. She noted that the key objectives of the partnership aligns with the GAVI-UNICEF mission, which is to increase equitable access to vaccines for every child and strengthen health systems, as well as to deliver quality and sustainable immunization services, among others, Mrs Odeyemi stressed that UNICEF remains steadfast in its support to the Niger State Government to achieve all the GAVI- UNICEF mission objectives by ensuring that no child is left unimmunized.



Strengthening Community Relations

Advocacy visits to the Bida, Suleja, and Minna Emirate Councils to foster trust and community collaboration.

The NiCare team, led by the Executive Secretary, in partnership with UNICEF, paid a courtesy visit to His Royal Highness, Alhaji (Dr.) Yahaya Abubakar, CFR, the Etsu Nupe of Bida Local Government Area (LGA). The purpose of the visit was to raise awareness about the Agency's initiatives and solicit the Royal Highness's support in enrolling vulnerable populations, particularly zero-dose children, through the GAVI-supported program. The Executive Secretary sought the Emirate's assistance in ensuring that beneficiaries access designated healthcare facilities and reiterated the Agency's commitment to providing equitable access to quality healthcare. Additionally, he urged His Royal Highness to advocate for community participation in these initiatives and underscored the importance of philanthropic contributions to leave no one behind.

A representative of UNICEF, Aliyu Issac, emphasized the critical role of community leaders in fostering public acceptance of health programs. He called on the Emirate to encourage families to utilize the free healthcare services offered through the partnership.

In a similar advocacy effort, the NiCare team and UNICEF engaged with the Zazzau Emirate Council in Suleja to strengthen healthcare initiatives. The delegation was warmly received by the Wambai of Zazzau, Suleja, Alhaji Musa Abubakar, who represented the Emir. This visit aimed to secure the Emirate's support for health programs focusing on children under five and women of childbearing age. The Executive Secretary commended the Emir for his invaluable contributions to previous public health campaigns and highlighted the pivotal role of traditional leaders in advancing public health efforts. During the visit, it was announced that 2,000 women and children had been enrolled in a free health insurance scheme through the partnership with UNICEF.

In response, the Wambai assured the delegation of the Emirate's unwavering support, pledging to engage district heads and encourage broader community participation. He also committed to keeping the Emir informed of the initiative's progress.



Further, NiCare, in collaboration with UNICEF, conducted an advocacy visit to His Royal Highness, Alhaji Umar Faruq Bahago, the Emir of Minna. This visit was part of the ongoing effort to address the challenge of zero-dose children—those who have not received age-appropriate vaccines—and to promote health-seeking behaviour among vulnerable populations in the state. The Executive Secretary noted that this UNICEF-supported initiative aligns with Governor Mohammed Umaru Bago's commitment to enhancing healthcare access for underserved communities. The program focuses on improving access to essential healthcare for women of childbearing age and children under five, fostering community acceptance, and achieving better health outcomes across the state.

His Royal Highness, Alhaji Umar Faruq Bahago, commended the initiative and pledged to support its implementation by encouraging community members to take advantage of the available services. He described the partnership as a vital step toward improving the welfare of his people.



Advocacy Visits



Visit to the Ministry of Primary Health Care



Advocacy visit to the Ministry of Information.



Advocacy visit to The Niger State Planning Commission.



Visit to the Ministry of Local Government and Chieftaincy Affairs



Visit to the Speaker of The Niger State House of Assembly.



Advocacy visit to The Niger State College of Education, Minna.

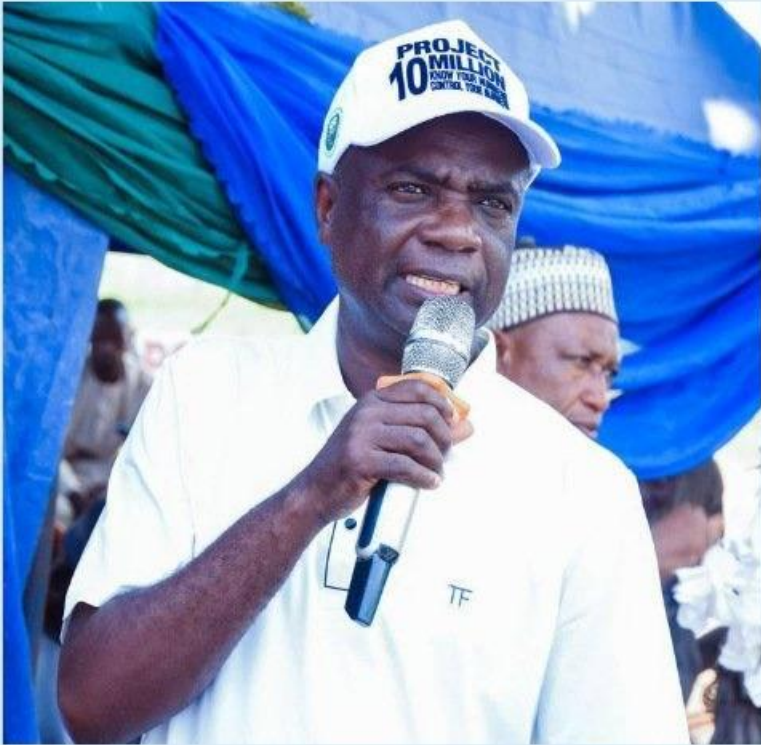


NiCare team visited mechanics at the Minna Eastern Bypass.



NiCare team visited the Medical Director and Management Unit of Unity Clinic, Kpakungu.

Expanding Program Reach



Chairman House Committee enrolls members of his constituents in Paikoro LGA.

The flag-off enrollment ceremony for Paikoro LGA, held in collaboration with NiCare, was a significant event that brought together key stakeholders in the healthcare sector.

In his welcome speech, the Commissioner Ministry of Secondary and Tertiary Health, Dr. Bello Tukur emphasized the importance of healthcare in everyday life, especially during economic hardships. He commended the member representing Paikoro LGA for initiating the health insurance scheme and expressed support for the project.

In his goodwill message, the Permanent Secretary Ministry of Primary Healthcare, Dr Abdullahi Imam also commended the member for his dedication to the well-being of his people and pledged their support for improving healthcare services in Paikoro LGA.

In his speech,the Executive Secretary NiCare, Sulayman Abu-bakr observed that free healthcare services can have a positive impact on healthcare outcomes, especially for the vulnerable populations. He also highlighted the launch of the Retiree Medical Insurance Package, approved by the governor, and encouraged other stakeholders to emulate the gesture.

The Honorable member representing Paikoro LGA, Honorable Umar Nasir Paiko, said the initiative was born out of the need to ensure the his people can access quality healthcare, given the challenges faced in accessing affordable healthcare. He announced that the enrollment will commence in Paiko and Kaffin Koro, with 300 indigenes to benefit from the health insurance scheme, which has been extended to three years. He encouraged the beneficiaries to take advantage of the scheme and report any inadequate services.

The event demonstrated the commitment of stakeholders to improving healthcare services in Paikoro LGA, and the collaboration between NiCare and the local government is expected to yield positive outcomes for the community.



Launch of Retirees Medical Insurance

Flag-off Retirees Medical Insurance Package (RMIP), alongside other key programs.

The launch of the Retiree Medical Insurance Package (RMIP) under the Niger State Contributory Health Scheme (NiCare) was a moment of gratitude, reflection, and commitment. This milestone underscores the state's dedication to ensuring senior citizens and retirees have access to quality healthcare.

The Executive Secretary and CEO of NiCare, Abu-Bakr Sulayman, MPH, expressed heartfelt appreciation for the contributions of retirees. He stated, *"Our elders have spent a lifetime building this state, contributing to its growth, and shaping the communities we live in today. This health insurance scheme is our way of expressing gratitude for their years of service and ensuring they live their golden years with dignity, peace of mind and access to quality healthcare services."*

Sulayman further highlighted the government's commitment to removing financial barriers to healthcare, aligning the initiative with the Governor's broader vision. *"Our Governor's vision for an inclusive healthcare system aligns perfectly with this initiative. We are not only safeguarding the health and wellbeing of our retirees but also setting a standard for leadership and social responsibility that all citizens of Niger State can be proud of."*

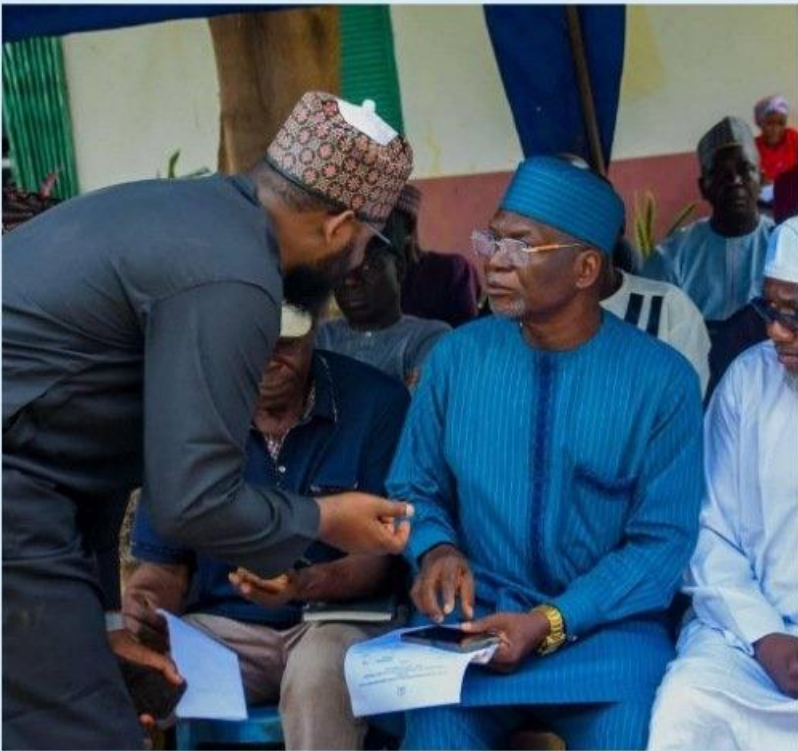
Stephen Zita, Chairman of the Pensioners and Joint Action Committee, lauded the scheme, recalling NiCare's advocacy meeting with retirees on 25th September 2024. He noted that the Executive Secretary had promised free health insurance during the meeting, a promise fulfilled with the scheme's launch. *"Today, 15th October 2024, that promise has been fulfilled. We are very grateful for this gesture, and we promise to promote this program among other retirees."* Zita also pledged to collaborate with the Association of Union Pensioners (AUP) to encourage all retirees in Niger State to enroll. During the event, on-the-spot enrollments were conducted, and retirees were informed they would receive their health cards within 30 days.



Dr. Bello Tukur, Hon. Commissioner for Secondary and Tertiary Healthcare, delivered the vote of thanks, expressing satisfaction with the event's success. He recalled the pivotal role retirees had played in establishing NiCare during their service years. Sharing a memorable anecdote, he recounted an advocacy visit with the former Head of Service, who enthusiastically embraced the scheme upon learning of its premiums and benefits. *"This scheme is a solution to many challenges, one we can collectively embrace,"* Tukur affirmed.

The flag off event was graced by key stakeholders; The Head of Service, represented by the Permanent Secretary Establishment, Hajiya Aisha T. Usman. Pioneer Executive Secretary of NiCare, Dr. Muhammad B. Usman. Immediate past Head of Service, Engr. Abubakar Salisu. Director General of the pension board and Alhaji Nasiru Saidu Namaska.

The event concluded on a high note, with a collective sense of partnership and commitment. It reflected NiCare's mission to provide sustainable healthcare access for all retirees and senior citizens in Niger State.



Enhancing Quality of Care

Intersectoral collaborations, including quarterly Quality Assurance (QA) Monitoring and Evaluation sessions with Hon. Umar Nasir Paiko.



The Executive Secretary, accompanied by the Chairman of the Niger State House Committee on Health, conducted a visit to the Primary Health Care Centre (PHCC) in Maitumbi, Chanchaga Local Government Area (LGA) and Model Clinic in Paikoro LGA, as part of the quarterly supervision exercise for Quality Assurance, Monitoring and Evaluation of healthcare facilities across the state.

During the visit, the Executive Secretary emphasized the significance of the joint supervision initiative as a testament to the collaborative efforts between the legislative and executive branches.

He noted that this partnership underscores NiCare's commitment to delivering quality and affordable healthcare services, in alignment with the former governor's vision of enhancing livelihoods in the state. He further commended the facility's staff for their dedication to providing care for NiCare enrolees, solicited constructive feedback for continuous improvement, and underscored the importance of increasing enrolment to broaden access to essential healthcare services.



Boosting Visibility

Media appearances to promote NiCare's health insurance initiatives across the state. The executive secretary alongside NiCare team visited different radio houses to discuss the operations and activities of the Agency and to also raise awareness about the importance of healthcare insurance to the residents of the state.

Reflecting on Progress



Enrollment of At Risk Children Project (ARC-P) beneficiaries into the State Health Insurance Scheme (Barkin Saleh Primary School).



Niger State Contributory Health Agency (NiCare) 2025 Budget Defence at the Niger State House of Assembly .



NiCare collaborated with Aspire Alliance for Niger State Youths to launch a free medical outreach at Maikunkele.



Strengthening Third-Party Relationships: A brief meeting before the MoU signing with Third-Party Administrators (TPA) to enhance operational efficiency.



Driving Innovation: The launch of the NiCare Fund Management System (NiFMS) to streamline fund management processes.



NiCare Strengthens ties with Private Healthcare Providers.



Engaging Faith Leaders: Sensitization meetings with religious leaders to promote health insurance awareness.



Empowering Stakeholders: A town hall meeting with the informal sector groups to address their health insurance needs and concerns.

Reflecting on Progress



The Clinton Health Access Initiative (CHAI) Team visit to the Executive Secretary NiCare



Dr Ado J.G Muhammad, Global Program Director, D-8 Organisation (Health and Social Protection Program) visit to the Executive Secretary NiCare



Late Hon. Danlami Abdullahi Saku (Executive Chairman Katcha, LGA) visit to the Executive Secretary NiCare



Visit from NHIA state team to the Executive Secretary NiCare



The Executive Secretary of NiCare hosted the National Senior Citizens Centre (NSCC) Niger State Stakeholders Committee



UNICEF team visited the Executive Secretary NiCare



Delegates from the Association of Health Records and Information Practitioners of Nigeria visited the Executive Secretary NiCare

INTERVIEW



Interview with Sulayman Abu-bakr the Executive Secretary/CEO of NiCare

What would you consider your most significant achievement since assuming office a year ago?

Our agency has achieved remarkable milestones over the past year. My most significant achievement, however, is leading a dynamic team to develop and implement groundbreaking initiatives that are transforming universal health coverage in Niger State. We have successfully streamlined our focus and repositioned NiCare as a result-driven, goal-oriented agency, demonstrating high levels of performance and accountability.

In specific terms, I would say our significant achievements include: revamping of our organisational structure, capacity building for our staff, launching of RMIP, formal sector health insurance scheme, operational guideline review, farmers health insurance, enhanced visibility of NiCare brand, commencement of our TISHIP, MoU with TPAs, Niger Foods, Digital transformation of our processes.

How has NiCare evolved under your leadership, and what role have you played in shaping its growth?

Under my leadership, NiCare has experienced unprecedented transformation. It is no longer business as usual. We have pioneered numerous reforms, including the introduction of our Strategic Blueprint, a document that ensures transparency and accountability. By embracing leadership by example and management by objective, our top management actively supports and guides our team to thrive. Additionally, we have fostered a

culture of innovation and creativity, empowering our staff to develop impactful solutions.

Can you share success stories or testimonials that highlight your impact?

We have successfully (re)established the trust and confidence of key stakeholders. The quality of our work speaks volumes, as evidenced by the results of recent assessments showing increased client satisfaction. These achievements have been repeatedly echoed by testimonials from stakeholders and beneficiaries who recognize the improved services NiCare delivers.

How have you improved healthcare delivery or services within NiCare, and what innovative approaches have you introduced?

We have introduced several initiatives to significantly enhance healthcare delivery in Niger State. Key among these is the revamping of our Quarterly Quality Assessments (Q&A), which now includes multidisciplinary support, such as participation by the House Committee Chairman on Health. Coordination meetings with healthcare providers ensure that our quality improvement efforts are targeted and impactful. Additionally, we have revised our operational guidelines and deployed digital systems to monitor and improve healthcare delivery.

What milestones have you achieved in terms of policy implementation, partnerships, or collaborations?

In terms of policy, we have secured approval to scale up the formal sector health insurance scheme under the NHIA Act 2022 and revised our operational guidelines to enhance efficiency. On the collaboration front, we have forged strategic partnerships with local and international organizations, including CHAI, UNICEF, Global Affairs Canada, and Gavi, enabling us to expand health insurance coverage and access technical support.

What were some of the biggest challenges you faced when you first assumed office, and how did you address them?

Upon assuming office, we faced challenges such as limited human resources, inadequate office accommodation, work tools, and insufficient operational vehicles. Additionally, there was a notable capacity gap among staff. To address these issues, we prioritized capacity-building initiatives and secured the necessary resources to ensure more seamless operations.

How have you navigated the complexities of healthcare management, and what lessons have you learned?

Managing the complexities of healthcare requires strong-willed decision-making. Drawing from my experience at the National Primary Health Care Development Agency (NPHCDA), I have learned the importance of making tough but necessary choices for organizational growth. Remaining focused on the larger vision has been critical to overcoming these challenges.

What obstacles have you encountered in implementing your vision for NiCare, and how have you overcome them?

We inherited several obstacles, including outdated operational guidelines, a critical NHIA audit report, and limited financial resources. With the support of directors and partners, we mobilized resources and revamped the operational framework, enabling us to implement reforms effectively.

How have you managed stakeholder expectations and built trust and confidence?

NiCare has become a model agency that prioritizes results and accountability. We have engaged stakeholders at every stage, ensuring transparency in our operations and

demonstrating value-for-money. By consistently delivering on our commitments, we have strengthened trust and confidence among partners and beneficiaries.

What are some ongoing challenges you face, and how are you working to resolve them?

Persistent challenges include shortages in human resources, lack of permanent office accommodation, and limited operational vehicles. However, we are optimistic that these issues will be addressed with the support of His Excellency, the Executive Governor, in the near future.

What are your top priorities for the next year, and how do you plan to achieve them?

This year, we aim to scale up the formal sector health insurance scheme for public servants and political appointees. We will establish critical project implementation units to oversee quality of care, launch our digital platforms, and fully embrace technological advancements to remodel health insurance delivery in Niger State.

How do you envision NiCare evolving in the next 2-3 years, and what role will you play in shaping its future?

NiCare is poised to become a hub of innovation and excellence, serving as a benchmark for other states. Over the next few years, I envision NiCare as a state-of-the-art agency of international repute, leading the charge in universal health coverage with groundbreaking initiatives.

What new initiatives or projects do you plan to launch, and how will they impact healthcare delivery?

We will launch initiatives to strengthen oversight on quality of care and leverage digital systems to improve efficiency. These projects will enhance healthcare delivery and ensure more equitable access to services for the people of Niger State.

How will you continue to engage with stakeholders, staff, and beneficiaries to achieve set goals?

We have established a robust coordination platform to monitor progress and address emerging challenges. Continued engagement with stakeholders, staff, and beneficiaries will ensure alignment with our vision and foster collective ownership of our goals.

What message would you like to convey to the NiCare community and partners?

To our stakeholders and partners, I encourage you to maintain faith in NiCare. We remain open to feedback and suggestions to continually improve the way we serve our community.

How has your leadership style evolved, and what have you learned about yourself?

My leadership style has evolved to accommodate the realities of the agency. Initially, I brought a fast-paced, results-driven approach, but I have learned to balance this with patience and adaptability to address systemic gaps. Collaboration with my team has been pivotal in achieving progress.

Do you have any personal stories that illustrate your journey?

Leading NiCare has been both challenging and rewarding. One defining moment was when we secured approval for the formal sector scheme—an uphill task that tested our resilience but ultimately showcased our team's dedication.

How do you balance leadership demands with personal well-being?

Balancing leadership with personal responsibilities has been challenging. However, the unrelenting support of my wife and family keeps me grounded, while I strive to create time for self-care and family commitments.

Is there anything else you'd like to share?

Reflecting on our journey so far, I am proud of what we have accomplished. Moving forward, I am confident in NiCare's ability to achieve even greater heights as we work collectively to improve healthcare in Niger State.

GAVI/ UNICEF Project Review Meeting

NiCare held a Project Review Meeting for GAVI (The Vaccine Alliance) / UNICEF 10,000 Supported Health Insurance Beneficiaries.

NiCare hosted a project review meeting focused on the implementation of the UNICEF-supported health insurance project targeting 10,000 beneficiaries. The meeting gathered desk officers, facility managers, and relevant stakeholders to assess progress and chart the way forward.

The review aimed to address key areas, including enrollment of beneficiaries, utilization of health services by enrollees, data collection and reporting, availability and quality of healthcare services.

The UNICEF representative, Adamu Mamba delivered an in-depth presentation on the Zero Dose, which focuses on identifying and vaccinating children who have not received any routine immunisations. He emphasized that reaching these children is critical to closing immunisation gaps and reducing preventable diseases.

He also stressed that the partnership between NiCare and GAVI/UNICEF offers a unique opportunity to enhance both healthcare access and immunisation uptake, ultimately improving health outcomes for communities.

The Executive Secretary of NiCare, Sulayman Abu-Bakr, highlighted the need for increased service utilisation by beneficiaries.

He stated that "As an Agency, our priority is to improve health outcomes across the state.". He assured participants that NiCare would not hesitate to impose sanctions where necessary, encouraging facilities to conduct outreach programs to expand access. He further emphasized that health insurance would serve as a tool to improve immunisation coverage and urged all partners to align efforts towards that goal.

Some of the stakeholders present at the meeting were from the Ministry of Primary Healthcare, M and E consultant UNICEF Kaduna office, Director M and E Niger State Planning Commission.



2024 SCORECARD

One year of NiCare's effort in "Implementing the improving livelihoods" of His Excellency, Farmer Mohammed Umaru Bago NEW NIGER Agenda

NiCare has been guided by a 4-point strategic priority

Pillar 1



Strengthening Institution

- Restructured our organisational structure and clarified roles and specificity of functions.
- Updated our enabling Operational Guidelines for efficient and accountable delivery of our mandate.
- Improved capacity of staff to be fit-for-purpose in driving our strategic blueprint.
- Implemented internal control mechanisms and revamp financial management system.
- Provided work tools to enhance efficiency and productivity of staff.
- Created atmosphere that foster innovation and creativity.
- Pioneered the productivity award to reward exceptional staff and pioneer staff of NiCare Niger State.

Pillar 3



Increase Health Insurance Coverage

- Increased health insurance coverage by ~39.3% (from 86,880 in 2023 to 121,024 in 2024) in one year.
- Increased vulnerable persons health insurance coverage by ~85% (from 3,816 in 2023 to 7,077 in 2024).
- Engaged private sector to enroll employees in the contributory health insurance scheme.
- Provided health insurance to 34,600+ women and children, improving maternal health and reducing zero-dose children with GAVI/ UNICEF & CHAI support.
- Signed MoU with Niger Foods to enroll 350,000 farmers in the contributory healthcare scheme.
- Launched the Retiree Medical Insurance Package (RMIP).
- Started the Tertiary Institutions Social Health Insurance Programme (TISHIP) for students.
- Expanded the formal sector and political appointees' health insurance scheme.
- Boosted quality of care from 77.2% (Q4 2023) to 94.2% (Q4 2024).
- Partnered with Third Party Administrators (TPAs) to expand enrolment and improve services.
- Increased maternal and child health service utilisation from 15.6% (2023) to 36.3% (Dec 2024).

Pillar 2



Rebranding Cooperate Communication for enhanced visibility

- Pioneered the productivity award to reward exceptional staff and pioneer staff of NiCare.
- Engaged professional associations.
- Sensitisation meetings with traditional and religious leaders.
- Media appearances to raise awareness of the general public on NiCare services.
- Developed and disseminated Information, Education, and Communication materials across the state.
- Strengthened help desk and feedback systems.
- Town hall meetings with informal sector actors.
- Conducted operational research to generate insights on client utilisation and satisfaction with healthcare services.

Pillar 4



Digital transformation

- Set up an infostructure for ICT operations.
- Institutionalised electronic file management system.
- Optimisation of the NiCare website in line with "Niger State domain".
- Launch of NiCare Fund Management System (NiFMS).
- Introduction of e-voucher to strengthen financial management processes in the agency.
- Developed comprehensive M&E system for tracking performance.
- Finalised the enrolle management system.

CELEBRATION MESSAGES FOR THE EXECUTIVE SECRETARY'S ONE YEAR IN OFFICE

In my opinion NiCare is the most improved agency in terms of service delivery in the State. The programs initiated are far reaching and well thought out. The ES has also shown a strong will to lead the agency efficiently and effectively to achieve where others failed.

Hon. Sadiq Yusuf,
Deputy Chief of Staff to the Governor

Mr Sulayman Abu-Bakr is a gentleman that has positively impacted the healthcare delivery system in Niger state within a very short time. He has brought youthful energy, professionalism, and charisma to Nicare. He is an excellent example of what can be achieved when young professionals are given the chance and opportunity to participate in governance. With his achievements so far, I am confident that our dream of making every resident of Niger state have access to quality healthcare at the time of need without undergoing any financial hardship will soon be a reality. He re-enforces my belief that a new Niger is upon us.

Hon. Dr Bello Tukur
Commissioner Ministry of Secondary and Tertiary Health, Niger State

Under the leadership of Sulayman Abubakar, NiCare has made remarkable strides in advancing the New Niger Agenda. In just one year, NiCare has significantly expanded health insurance coverage, ensuring more Nigerlites have access to affordable and quality healthcare. Through innovative programs and strategic partnerships, Sulayman has strengthened the agency's capacity to deliver essential health services, particularly to vulnerable populations. His dedication to improving health outcomes aligns seamlessly with the Governor's New Niger Agenda which focuses on Improved Livelihoods. We are proud to have him as a key partner in our collective mission.

Hon. Mustapha Ndajiwo,
Commissioner, Niger state planning commission

Niger State Contributory Healthcare Agency (NiCare) has been in the news for all the right reasons of late. I heartily congratulate my brother and friend Sulayman Abu-bakr on his first year anniversary in office as the Executive Secretary/CEO of NiCare. He has brought innovative and result-oriented leadership to bare in his stewardship at the Agency so far. Given my vantage position as entrusted on me by my colleagues, I can see what happens in every State, and I have definitely seen strategic improvements in NiCare in so short a time. Congratulations ES

Dr Simeon Onyemaechi,
MD/CEO Anambra State Health Insurance Agency and Chairman Forum of CEOs of State Social Health Insurance Agencies in Nigeria

Mr Sulayman Abu-bakr's tenure in office has so far brought the work of his organization in the spotlight with the constant milestone achievements that have been attained during the year in review. His ability to think strategically towards improving access to affordable healthcare across Niger State and highlighting the

various advantages of the Niger State Contributory Health Insurance Scheme has led him to partnerships with various demographics otherwise not imagined by the agency before his assuming its leadership. The excitement that greets a keen observer like myself into what is achievable in NiCare is informed by the above-mentioned effects on the E.S' skills and competencies on the overall performance of the organisation.

Hon. Mukthar Baloni,
Past Executive Chairman, Kaduna North LGA

The Niger State Contributory Health Agency, known as NiCare, is among the fastest-growing health insurance agencies in Nigeria. The current leadership has built upon the achievements of previous administrations, effectively positioning the agency to deliver quality, affordable, and equitably distributed health services to the people of Niger State.

A key factor in this progress is Sulayman Abu-Bakr's strong political will to reach essential milestones. He adopts an inclusive leadership style and is results-oriented. While his passion for the mission might sometimes come across as insensitivity to the challenges involved in executing tasks, his commitment to the well-being of everyone is evident. Overall, I believe that NiCare is a trailblazing agency that is well on its way to achieving Universal Health Coverage in Niger State in the near future. This mission is feasible with the continued support of Farmer Governor Mohammed Umaru Bago.

Dr. Fabong Jemchang
Past DG
Plateau state Contributory Healthcare Management Agency

Heartfelt Congratulations on Your One-Year Anniversary

Dear Sir,
As you mark one year of impactful leadership at NiCare, we extend our warmest congratulations to you. Your vibrancy, intelligence, and unwavering dedication have been truly inspiring. You are a man of vision and grit, whose impeccable leadership has steered the agency toward significant milestones. Your commitment to making NiCare a pillar of support for the people of Niger State speaks volumes about your passion for service and progress. May your journey ahead continue to be filled with groundbreaking achievements that leave a lasting legacy. Wishing you continued success as you lead with purpose and excellence."

CHAI
The Executive Secretary's leadership has had a profound impact on the Agency's growth and efficiency. Notably, his leadership has increased awareness about NiCare and led to the restructuring of the Agency, including the creation of Finance and Accounts department. One of his significant achievements was organizing a retreat to re-strategize the Agency's agenda, which resulted in the development of the 4 cardinal points agenda. This move demonstrates his commitment to planning and executing effective strategies. The department has been empowered to achieve its mandate, with increased priority on financial appropriation. This has enabled the provision of essential office tools, incentives, and improvements to the work environment. Looking ahead, the Agency aims to expand the formal sector in the state health insurance scheme, secure more conducive office accommodations, and become

Congratulatory Messages

the best state health insurance Agency in Nigeria. Ultimately, the goal is to achieve Universal Health Coverage.

On a personal note, the Executive Secretary's performance has been exceptional. His generosity, kindness, and inclusive leadership style have earned him widespread appreciation. The Administration department is grateful for his outstanding performance and looks forward to witnessing more successes together.

Ramatu Ismail Aliyu
Director Administrative Department NiCare

The coming of the current Executive Secretary to Niger State Contributory Health Agency has been a blessing. He is a dynamic leader with high administrative acumen. He gave the Agency tremendous visibility and credibility in the comity of MDAs in Niger State. He multiplied health insurance coverage in less than one year of his stewardship, encompassing a more diverse group of Nigerlites. A workaholic, with an eye for details and quality. With him in charge, the sky is the starting point for NiCare. More grease to your elbows sir. Happy one year anniversary in office.

Pharm Abdul Musa
Director Planning Research and Statistics NiCare

As we celebrate Executive Secretary Sulayman Abu-bakr's one-year anniversary, I acknowledge the transformative impact he's had on NiCARE. The establishment of the Account Department under his administration demonstrates his strategic vision.

His leadership has fostered a culture of excellence, innovation, and teamwork, inspiring staff, stakeholders, and partners. I'm impressed by his commitment to transparency, accountability, and inclusivity.

Thank you, Executive Secretary Sulayman Abu-bakr, for your dedication, expertise, and passion. I'm confident your continued leadership will propel NiCARE to greater heights.

Fatima Imam Jibrin
Director, Finance and Accounts.

The Executive Secretary's leadership has significantly influenced the Agency's operational efficiency and growth over the past year. Key actions include implementing technology solutions, process optimization, and workforce development.

In terms of growth, the Executive Secretary has contributed to expanding coverage, strengthening partnerships with healthcare providers, and enhancing the Agency's impact.

Regarding provider services, the Executive Secretary's role has had a positive impact. This includes improved efficiency, enhanced communication, and increased compliance.

The Department of Provider Services has been empowered to drive its mandate through streamlined claim processes, provider engagement, quality improvement initiatives, compliance oversight, and review of operational guidelines.

Looking ahead, key expectations for the Agency's development and success under the Executive Secretary's continued leadership include:

- Enhanced provider network
- Innovative product offerings
- Streamlined processes
- Data-driven decision-making
- Compliance and risk management
- Provider satisfaction
- Talent development
- Digital transformation

On a personal note, the Executive Secretary's leadership style has been impressive. His innovative approach has encouraged experimentation, learning, and adaptation. This mindset has positively impacted work and staff dynamics, fostering a culture of continuous improvement.

Dr Sa'ad Saleh Galma
Director Standards and Quality Assurance Department NiCare

Notably, the Executive Secretary has driven significant strides in digitizing NiCare services. Under his guidance, initiatives such as optimizing the agency website, automating claims management, and creating a user-friendly online enrollment portal have been implemented. These innovations have streamlined operations and improved service delivery, demonstrating the Executive Secretary's commitment to leveraging technology.

The department has also been empowered to drive its mandate, with the Executive Secretary providing necessary tools, training, and resources to enhance departmental capacity. This includes fostering a culture of accountability, collaborative work environments, and ensuring team members have access to required knowledge and skills.

Looking ahead, expectations for the agency's development and success under the Executive Secretary's continued leadership include continued growth in enrollment, deeper technology integration, and sustained improvements in healthcare service quality. The agency is also expected to strengthen collaborations with stakeholders and achieve greater financial sustainability.

On a personal note, the Executive Secretary's leadership style is both inclusive and transformational. By fostering open communication, promoting teamwork, and recognizing individual contributions, he has created a positive and motivating work environment. This approach has enhanced staff morale, encouraged innovation, and promoted efficiency within the team. His support and guidance have been instrumental in professional growth and contributions to the agency's mission. The Executive Secretary's leadership style aligns with research on effective leadership, which highlights the importance of transformational leadership in driving organizational success."

HICT NiCare

The Executive Secretary's leadership has had a significant impact on the Agency's operational efficiency and growth over the past year. His result-oriented approach has driven the Agency to achieve its best outcomes, and his strategic thinking has been instrumental in this success.

In terms of marketing the Agency, the Executive Secretary has played a crucial role in promoting its initiatives. He has successfully engaged stakeholders through advocacy and sensitization programs, targeted various MDAs and institutions, and leveraged media engagement to improve awareness.

More Congratulatory Messages

The department has also been empowered to drive its mandate under the Executive Secretary's leadership. He has provided a conducive work environment, necessary tools, and resources to facilitate the department's success.

Looking ahead, the key expectation is that the Agency will continue to develop and succeed under the Executive Secretary's leadership. With sustained stakeholder engagement, the community will take ownership of the Scheme's aspirations, ensuring its uptake and success.

On a personal note, the Executive Secretary's leadership style is impressive. He is result-oriented, and his approach has positively impacted staff dynamics. His expectation of high performance from team members has raised the bar, and the Agency is likely to achieve great things under his leadership.

Pharm Attahiru Shehu Malagi
Director Operations Development NiCare

The ES is a leader in the true sense of the word. He is determined, focused and consistent. A man of integrity, transparency and accountability.

Pharm Amina Nana Kolo
Head Claims Management Unit NiCare

Sulayman Abu-Bakr MPH, ES-CEO NiCare (Boss Like None Other),

I am particularly impressed by your ability to balance technical rigor with practical considerations/facilitate cross-functional collaborations. Your leadership has not only enhanced our unit's/Dep't/Agency performance but also inspired me to grow professionally and strive for excellence.

Please accept my heartfelt congratulations on your one-year anniversary in the office! I look forward to continuing our work together and achieving even greater success in the years to come.

Musa Haruna Tukura
Head, Monitoring & Evaluation Unit.

Congratulations on your one year in office
Under the visionary leadership of our CEO, Sulayman Abubakr our organization attained new heights of success. His unwavering dedication, strategic foresight, and commitment to excellence has inspired a culture of innovation and teamwork in NiCare. We salute his exceptional leadership style and look forward to continued growth and achievements.

Habibah Lami Umar
Head of informal sector NiCare

The executive Secretary/CEO is more of a mentor to us, a leader that derives pleasure in paving ways for staff growth and capacity building. I cannot count how many opportunities of personal development he has shared and supported me to do. In just a year of his leadership, he has shown each staff that your worth lies in your capacity by giving all staff equal opportunities and rewarding hard work. Indeed where others stand he stands out. It is a privilege knowing him and being a mentee to him. Sir, may the successes we will achieve under your leadership continue to be exemplary under the guidance and protection of the Almighty. Happy One year in office Super Mentor/Boss.

Maryam Shuaibu
BHCPF Lead

To an exceptional leader and mentor, Sulayman Abu-Bakr, Executive Secretary/CEO NiCare We pay tribute to your unwavering dedication, unshakeable principles, and compassionate heart. Your leadership style is a shining example of what it means to be a true team player. Your ability to carry all staff along, fostering an environment of inclusivity and collaboration, has been a hallmark of your tenure. You've instilled in us the importance of teamwork, empowering each of us to take ownership of our work and strive for excellence.

Your mantra of 'no one should do someone's job' has been a guiding principle, promoting accountability efficiency, and growth. You've encouraged us to be our best selves, providing the necessary tools and support to help us succeed. We're grateful for your kindness, empathy, and understanding.

You've been more than just a boss; you've been a mentor, a friend, and a source of inspiration.

Thank you for being an extraordinary leader. We're honored to work under your guidance and will strive to carry forward the values and principles you've instilled in us.

Mariam Umar
PRO NiCare

I wish to congratulate you on this remarkable stage of your journey. These past 12 months have been commendable, with landmark achievements.

Your leadership style and all-inclusive leadership qualities have proven your Worth as a worthy ambassador of success. As you strive along, we welcome your resilience and true leadership style as we support you fully to achieving the best in the course of time.

Once again congratulations.

Godwin Tolunu
Desk Officer Gurara LGA

First of all I will thank the staff of Nicare for their moral support to all our facilities across the 25 LGA in Niger state. I also appreciate the effort of the executive secretary for his vision and mission in seeing the achievement made in terms of enrollment of vulnerable people and prompt monthly capitation without delaying in my LGA both GAC and UNICEF/GAVI with in one year in office is a great achievement in the memory of my life which i will not forget. In view of the above, i wish all the staff of Nicare a "HAPPY NEW YEAR".

Aliyu Mohammed
Desk Officer Lavun LGA

Productivity Award Ceremony

The Niger State Contributory Health Agency-NiCare, has held its 2024 end of year Productivity Award Ceremony to honor the exceptional dedication and contributions of its staff, as well as celebrate the achievements of its pioneer members who have retired after years of service.

The award night, the first of its kind in Niger State, which took place at the Athena Event Centre, Minna had in attendance top government officials and friends of the Agency.

Speaking at the event, Sulayman Abu-bakr, MPH, Executive Secretary and CEO of NiCare, highlighted the agency's progress under his leadership. Guided by a four-point agenda aligned with the Farmer Governor Mohammed Umaru Bago's vision of improved livelihoods of the New Niger Agenda, NiCare has achieved significant milestones in improving the health and welfare of the people of Niger State.

Sulayman emphasized that these achievements were a collective effort driven by the passion and resilience of NiCare's team. "Today's ceremony is a testament to the critical role our staff plays in transforming lives," he said.

While celebrating its progress, NiCare remains committed to addressing the challenges ahead. Sulayman called on staff to maintain their dedication and innovative spirit to continue improving the livelihoods of Niger State residents. The Speaker of the Niger State House of Assembly, Rt.Honourable Abdulmalik Sarkin Daji commended the Executive Secretary for actualising the Scheme's mandate and working towards achieving Farmer Governor Mohammed Umaru Bago's agenda of Improved Livelihood of all residents of the state. He then challenged other heads of Agencies to imitate the gesture of Sulayman Abu-bakr, to reward their staff as it would motivate the workers to be dedication to their jobs.

Hon. Sarkin Daji noted that the event was a challenge to all leaders to reward excellent and dedicated workers. He praised the executive secretary of NiCare for actualising the agency's mandate, highlighting the creativity and commitment of the youth in the current administration. "This is what you get when you give the youths the opportunity to serve. The youths are always creative, so this is the true manifestation of the creativity of the youth. Sulayman is very creative, proactive, committed, and dogged. I appreciate his sagacity all the time," said the Speaker. Also speaking, the Commissioner for Secondary and Tertiary Health, Dr Bello Tukur, expressed satisfaction with NiCare's achievements and noted that the event aligns with the Governor's vision of recognising merit and services.

The Head of Service, Alhaji Abubakar Sadiq, also noted that the event was in line with the Governor's approval for a state productivity award for civil servants across all Ministries and Parastatals

Goodwill messages were given by the State Commissioner Budget and Planning Commission, Mustapha Ndajiwo, the Special Adviser to the Governor on Special Duties, Dr Murtala Mohammed Bagana and many others.

Highlights of the occasion were the presentation of awards to recipients in different categories for their contributions to the Agency.

First Category

1. Dr Bello Tukur, **Commisioner for Secondary and Tertiary Health.**
2. Dr Mustapha Jibril Alheri, **Former Commisioner for Health**
3. Dr Muhammad M Makusidi, **Former Commissioner for Health**
4. Dr Mohammed B Usman, **Pioneer Executive Secretary**

Second category - Retired staff

1. Alh Mohammed Ndanusa Gaba, (Director Admin)
2. Ibrahim Mahmood, (Director HICT)
3. Samma Umar (Marketing Officer)

Three most performing staff of the Agency were also recognised for their exceptional productivity.

1. Habibah L Umar - Head, Informal sector
2. Maryam Shuaibu- BHCPF Lead
3. Pharm Aliyyu Gimba - Claims Officer

Gwape International Troupe also entertained the guests with a dance drama, showcasing the objectives of Niger State Contributory Health scheme.

The ceremony also marked a renewed commitment to NiCare's vision of ensuring accessible and reliable healthcare for all.

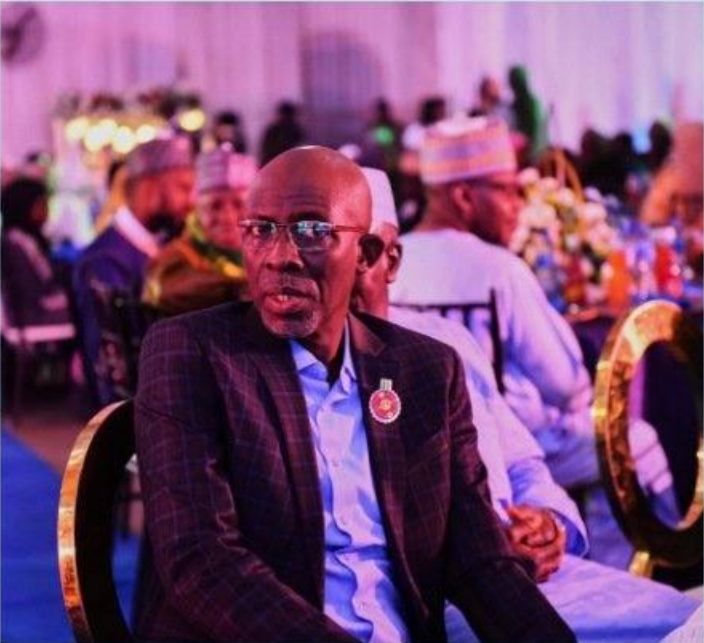
Other guests in attendance include, Sadiq Yusuf (Deputy Chief of Staff to the Governor), Hon. Umar Nasir Paiko, (Chairman House Committee on Health, Niger State House of Assembly) with other members, Permanent Secretaries, Heads of Government Agencies, Chairman ALGON.



More on the Award Ceremony



More on the Award Ceremony



More on the Award Ceremony



Executive Secretary/CEO's Letter



As we celebrate our first year in office, I want to take this opportunity to reflect on our journey so far and extend my heartfelt gratitude to each one of you. Your unwavering support and steadfast commitment to improving livelihoods goal of the New Niger Agenda championed by Mr Governor, **Farmer Mohammed Umaru Bago** have been the cornerstone of our progress.

Over the past year, we have witnessed remarkable improvements in our mission to make quality and accessible healthcare a reality for all. These achievements are not accidental, they are the direct result of your hard work, resilience, and shared determination to uplift the lives of the people we serve. The New Niger agenda thrives because of the collective spirit of sacrifice and teamwork that defines us as a team and as a family.

This occasion also calls us to pause and remember those who are no longer with us. Let us keep our retired and departed colleagues in our thoughts and prayers. Their selfless service and dedication to this Agency remain a guiding light for us as we continue to build on the foundation they helped establish. May we honor their memories by remaining steadfast in our shared commitment to the values they upheld.

As we forge ahead, let us pray for wisdom and clarity for our leaders, courage and strength for our people, and sustained progress for our state. We must not lose sight of our individual and collective responsibilities—to our government, to our communities, and to one another. It is only through unity, mutual respect, and a shared vision that we can achieve the goals we have set for ourselves.

While this one-year milestone is worthy of celebration, it is also a reminder that our work is far from complete.

Our targets remain high, but they are not insurmountable. Every challenge we face is an opportunity to prove our dedication and resolve. The real work begins now, and I am confident that with the same energy, passion, and collaborative spirit you have demonstrated over the past year, we will achieve even greater milestones.

NiCare stands as a testament to what we can accomplish when we come together with a shared purpose. Let us continue to lead with compassion, act with integrity, and strive for excellence in all that we do. Remember, the impact we make today will shape the future for generations to come.

Thank you for your dedication, your hard work, and for being an integral part of the NiCare family. Let us continue to build a legacy of service and transformation, together.

Warm regards,
Sulayman Abu-bakr
Executive Secretary/CEO
Niger State Contributory Health Agency
(NiCare)

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NIGER STATE CONTRIBUTORY HEALTH AGENCY

(NiCare)



Building a healthy future in Niger State, starts with providing essential healthcare services, enabling everyone to be at their best.

OUR SERVICES COVERS:

- Treatment of Malaria, RTI, Hypertension, Diabetes Mellitus, Common Infections, Eye conditions, Gastro enteritis, etc.
- Surgeries for Appendicitis, Hernia, Hemimorphy and Hemiotomy, Cataract extraction, Fibroid, Enlarged prostate, etc.
- Antenatal services; Delivery including Caesaren section and Postnatal services, Neonatal services and Immunization services.
- Laboratory and Radiology investigations including X-rays, Ultrasound scan, Abdomenopelvic, etc.
- Drugs for covered services.
- Optical and Dental services, referral and many more.



Health care providers:

ACCREDITED PUBLIC AND PRIVATE HOSPITALS

Visit our website for more information: www.nicare.nigerstate.gov.ng
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